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Peking May 12

No. 1 Lords

No. 74

Confidential

—o—

No. July 21.

—o—

Japan, Formosa and China.

The Queen

Mr Disraeli

Circulate

D

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Pekin
May 1st 1874

1874
identical

My Lord.

In continuation of my despatch No. 42 of the 30th of April. I beg to refer your Lordship to my despatches of last year enumerated in the margin which were written during the stay of the Japanese Ambassador Soyesima in Pekin.

1 dated May 15th
11 - 25th
16 - 26th
23 from 4th
75 dated Aug. 20th

From the conversations of the Ambassador with myself and my colleagues reported in those despatches

Earl of Derby

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despatches, it will have been seen that, independently of the special objects of his Mission, viz. the exchange of Ratifications of the Treaty concluded in 1872, and the delivery of a letter of congratulation from the Mikado of Japan to the Emperor of China, the Japanese addressed himself also to three other points of interest. He asserted the dependence of Lewchew upon Japan, and as a consequence the title of

Japan

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Japan for reparation for the murder
of certain Liuchiuans shipwrecked
upon Formosa. This reparation has
implied that the Japanese would
themselves exact from the Aborigines
of Formosa, if the Chinese declared
these people beyond their control.
In the second place, therefore, he
pressed for a declaration on this
subject. Thirdly, he pressed for a
somewhat similar declaration — a —
regarding the relations of the Chinese
with

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with Corea.

These questions, manifestly, were not raised merely for the purpose of quickening the Yamen's movements in the matter of the Audience, although a last attempt was beyond doubt being made at the Yamen to induce Sayesima to accept less than had been stipulated for in the discussion virtually closed at the time of his arrival, by the Representatives of

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of Western Powers; and the allusions to Formosa did beyond doubt greatly trouble the Yamen. The Japanese seemed set upon a military expedition either against Corea or Formosa, or both countries, but against the latter rather than the former. M. Legendre said to be an ex lieutenant of Engineers in the French Army, now naturalised as an American, was believed to be the prime mover of this scheme, which was also thought

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thought to have the support of Mr. de Long, the United States Minister in Japan. Mr. de Legendre as United States Consul General in Formosa visited the Formosan aborigines in their own country, and had made an agreement with them regarding the future treatment of shipwrecked foreigners, which has been found useful.

In a despatch received this morning from Sir H. Parkes, he informs

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informs me that the Japanese Secretary of State declares his Government to be but following the example set by the United States. That it simply proposes to chastise the Aborigines for acts done in 1871 and 1873, and to secure its subjects against — recurrence of such outrages as it is now about to punish. Sir H. Parkes observes that the guarantees last required do not appear at the same time not specified.

Yours

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My own impressions are strong indeed, when I look back to Soyesima's observations from first to last. I can entertain no doubt, that, all professions to the contrary notwithstanding the Japanese do as certainly as the Chinese themselves, consider the whole Island of Formosa to form part of the Chinese Empire, and that they are bent upon nothing less than the annexation of it. Soyesima enlarged upon the advantage

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advantage to foreign trade that such a change of manners would bring with it. To one in particular he dwelt upon the fact that the Japanese and the Formosan tribes were of the same race, and that the latter had been very harshly dealt with by the Chinese. His arguments, therefore, in justification of Japanese action were so far — inconsistent. And while he put forward castigation of the Aborigines whom the Chinese were powerless to

punish

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furnish, as a plea for possible proceedings on the part of Japan in Formosa, he was at the same time implying that Japan would be influenced in these proceedings by a sympathy with the Aborigines as sufferers at the hands of the Chinese. This, as I wrote to Sir H. Parkes, is the only instance in which I found the Ambassador guilty of cant, or otherwise than apparently straightforward.

As

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As to the purpose of the Japanese. The notion prevalent amongst the Legations here is that the Expedition is an échappatoire for the military under of the late party in Japan, which is to find —.— occupation in the formation of a military colony. But on Japanese policy I do not presume to —.— speculate. As for as the Chinese are concerned. They seem mortified and indignant, but more desirous of

Ignoring

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ignoring the true character of what
is occurring than of anything else.
They speak truth but upon one
point, viz. as regards the ——
completeness of their sovereignty
over Formosa. As it has been well
remarked, or should as listen dream
of admitting the incompleteness of
our own in New Zealand, where a
large portion of the native ——
population is virtually independent
of us. For the rest, although it

LRS

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was mentioned that the punishment of the Formosans was discussed last year by the Japanese,— the President Yung has admitted that it was to Mr. Magers —, the Ministers made to our clerics it, and they declare themselves equally ignorant of the approach of a Japanese minister, although it is known at Tientsin that preparations are being made to receive him there.

The Japanese will, therefore, very probably establish themselves in

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in Formosa without hindrance, and if they are able to keep it, as I have before said, I shall not lament the change of hands. With foreign aid, however, such as China can certainly obtain by paying for it, the Island might easily be recaptured, and if it were, we should have cause to regret that it had ever been lost. Chinese pride would be dangerously inflated by such a success.

I have the honor to be

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I am with the highest respect.
My Lord,
your Lordship's most obedient
humble servant
Thomas Francis Wade.